



had been "above board on all occasions". But most telling of all, when he was elected vice-president, Shekhawat surprised his own allies by polling 74 votes from the non-NDA camp. The saffron camp is hoping for a repeat of that trick.

The Congress is all too aware of Shekhawat's lethal charm and popularity. After all, it was Congress candidate Sushil Kumar Shinde that he had defeated in that vice-presidential election. The Shekhawat factor weighed heavily in the selection of the UPA candidate. Pawar gave the game away when Sonia Gandhi announced Pratibha Patil's name by adding that the lady is also a Shekhawat. Even the gender factor was socially engineered to take on the Thakur. When Patil tried to play the caste card against Shekhawat, she was trumped. On arriving in Delhi, she cheerfully announced that she planned to call on him. But Shekhawat, well-versed in the nuances of realpolitik, realised that if a *bahu* from his community asked for his blessings, it would be churlish of him to contest against her. Pre-empting this move, Shekhawat drove down to Jodhpur House in the Capital, where Patil was camping. Coffee and small talk dominated the half-hour meeting.

Yet the game has only just begun and there could be many a slip between the cup and the lip. Citing regional compulsions, one of the NDA's own allies, the Shiv Sena, has announced that it will not support Shekhawat, backing Patil instead. Shiv Sena chief Bal Thackeray also accused Shekhawat of being indecisive. "When Kalam was in the race, Shekhawat withdrew. Now that Kalam is out, he is in. What kind of *saudebaazi* (trading) is this," he asked. This led to a storm of righteous indignation within the BJP. Few buy the Sena's theory of Maratha pride. Shekhawat's media manager, the BJP's fiery Sushma Swaraj, lashed back asking, "If we put up a Bengali leader, would the CPI(M) support him?" The BJP has threatened to review its ties with the Sena after the presidential polls. General Secretary Gopinath Munde pointed out that "during the last vice-presidential election, the Sena had no problems backing Shekhawat against another Maharashtrian." The Congress, too, has stepped up its campaign. It is critical of Shekhawat's decision to contest the elections without resigning from his vice-presidency. "He is not constitutionally bound to do so, but we feel that since Patil has resigned as governor, so should Shekhawat," says P.R. Dasmunshi, parliamentary affairs minister.

The born-again Third Front is yet to return Shekhawat's goodwill gesture and pledge its absolute support. Although Shekhawat says he's contesting as an Independent, few are fooled. As the CPI(M) says, he can't hide his life-long association with the BJP and the RSS. The TDP and the Samajwadi Party are divided on the question of supporting a saffron man, and yet don't want to support the Congress candidate. Some, like SP General Secretary Azam Khan, think it's a futile debate. "Mayawati formed the government three times with the help of the BJP, but did not lose out on Muslim votes," he told the media. His leaders, however, are tightlipped. Shekhawat is not. The Rajput leader says he is confident that "the numbers are in my favour... I don't want to disclose the basis". It is statements like these that scare the Congress.

DOING HIS MATHS: With some of his own allies turning against him, there is a tough battle ahead